CHAPTER 1

Sequences and discrete models

Chapter path

Objectives. Turn a story into a sequence; distinguish increment from rate; compute terms and sums; justify a variation; investigate a threshold.
Prerequisites. Algebraic manipulation, integer powers, percentages, affine function, Python loop.
Yearly reference point. 8–17 September: 8 hours, then revisits

Diagnostic: six questions, 10 minutes

Answer without consulting the lesson. Mark the questions for which help is needed. This diagnostic is not graded.

1. Calculate $3 + 2 \times 4$.
2. Calculate 2^0, 2^3 and 2^{-2}.
3. A population of 80 increases by 5 %. Give the new population.
4. For $f(x) = 3x - 2$, calculate $f(0)$ and $f(4)$.
5. How many integers are there from 3 to 10, endpoints included?
6. Which values does the loop `for k in range(4)` give to k?

After the diagnostic. Revisit the flagged topics with the teacher; redo a similar question, then explain the rule used.

Speaking and logic. In 90 seconds, explain the difference between index, term and number of terms. Give a counterexample to a rule guessed from three values.

Investigate before formalising

In pairs, compare two collection offers: 20 kg in the first week then 5 kg more each week; 20 kg then a 20 % increase each week. Conjecture which collects more in total over six weeks, then justify. Allow 10 min for investigation and 5 min for comparison.

Organisation. Individual investigation 5 min, comparison in pairs 5 min, class discussion 5 min. Keep a record of one attempt, even an unfinished one. A conjecture must then be justified.

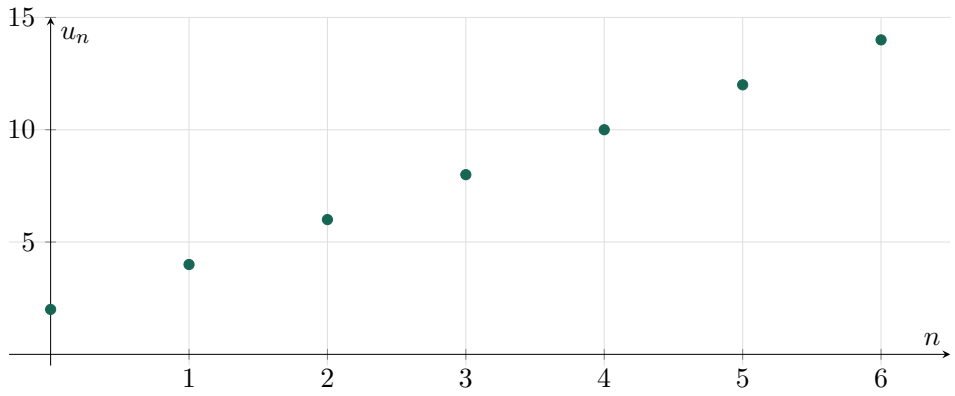
1.1 Defining and representing a sequence

Definition and results

A real sequence is a function whose variable is an integer: to each allowed index n corresponds a real number u_n. The notation (u_n) denotes the sequence, u_n a term. An explicit formula gives u_n directly in terms of n. A definition by recurrence gives a first term and a rule for passing from one term to the next. The representation is a set of points $(n; u_n)$: these points are not necessarily joined up.

Status and justification. Definition. The uniqueness of the terms obtained from a first term and a deterministic rule is accepted; no formal proof by induction is required.

Worked example. For $u_n = n^2 + 1$, $u_0 = 1$, $u_3 = 10$. For $v_0 = 1$ and $v_{n+1} = 2v_n + 1$, $v_1 = 3$, $v_2 = 7$, $v_3 = 15$. We cannot replace v_3 by $2 \times 3 + 1$: the rule applies to the previous term.



Terms of $u_n = 2n + 2$: only integer indices are plotted.

Watch out

The index is not the value. A finite list of terms does not determine a unique rule.

Immediate application. Calculate the first four terms of $w_0 = 2$, $w_{n+1} = w_n + 2n + 1$; suggest an explicit formula.

1.2 Arithmetic sequences

Definition and results

A sequence is arithmetic with common difference r if $u_{n+1} = u_n + r$ for every allowed index. Then $u_n = u_p + (n-p)r$ for $n \geq p$. If $r > 0$ it is strictly increasing; if $r < 0$, strictly decreasing; if $r = 0$, constant. The points lie on a straight line.

Status and justification. For fixed p, the sequence $v_n = u_p + (n-p)r$ satisfies $v_p = u_p$ and $v_{n+1} = v_n + r$. By uniqueness of the successive terms, $u_n = v_n$. The variation follows from the sign of $u_{n+1} - u_n = r$.

Worked example. A tank holds 140 L and receives 12 L per minute. After n minutes, $u_n = 140 + 12n$. At 5 min: 200 L. If we start the indexing at 1 with 140 L, we write $u_n = 140 + 12(n-1)$.

Watch out

Adding a constant percentage does not generally give an arithmetic sequence.

Immediate application. We know $u_3 = 17$ and $u_8 = 37$ for an arithmetic sequence. Determine r and u_0.

1.3 Geometric sequences

Definition and results

A sequence is geometric with common ratio q if $u_{n+1} = qu_n$. For $n \geq p$, $u_n = u_p q^{n-p}$, with the convention that an empty product equals 1. A constant rate t gives $q = 1 + t$. The variation is decided with $u_{n+1} - u_n = (q-1)u_n$. For $q < 0$, the signs may alternate.

Status and justification. The formula gives the first term, and multiplying it by q gives the next term. The uniqueness of the generation justifies the formula. For $q = 0$, all terms after the first are zero; treat this case directly.

Worked example. A quantity of 160 mg loses 25 % at each step: $u_n = 160(\frac{3}{4})^n$. The terms are positive and $u_{n+1} - u_n = -\frac{u_n}{4} < 0$. We obtain $u_2 = 90$ mg, without confusing a 25 % decrease with removing 25 mg.

Watch out

$q > 1$ is not enough to conclude that every geometric sequence is increasing: the sign of the first term matters.

Immediate application. Study the variation of $u_n = -2 \times 3^n$, then of $v_n = 2(-1)^n$.

1.4 Sums, indices and proofs

Definition and results

For $n \geq 1$, $1+2+\cdots+n = \dfrac{n(n+1)}{2}$. For $q \neq 1$ and $n \geq 0$, $1+q+\cdots+q^n = \dfrac{1-q^{n+1}}{1-q}$. For $q = 1$, the sum equals $n+1$. Hence, from u_p to u_n, an arithmetic sum equals $\dfrac{(n-p+1)(u_p+u_n)}{2}$; a geometric sum equals $\dfrac{u_p(1-q^{n-p+1})}{1-q}$ if $q \neq 1$.

Status and justification. Writing $S = 1 + \cdots + n$ in both directions, each pair in the sum $2S$ equals $n+1$, and there are n pairs. For $T = 1 + q + \cdots + q^n$, subtract $qT = q + \cdots + q^{n+1}$: $(1-q)T = 1 - q^{n+1}$. The case $q = 1$ must come before the division.

Worked example. For $u_n = 3 + 2n$, $u_2 + \cdots + u_6 = \dfrac{5(7+15)}{2} = 55$. For $v_n = 2 \times 3^n$, $v_0 + \cdots + v_3 = \dfrac{2(1-3^4)}{1-3} = 80$.

Watch out

Count the terms before using the formula: from 0 to n there are n+1.

Immediate application. Calculate $\sum_{k=2}^{5} 2^k$ without the summation symbol in the answer.

1.5 Conjecturing a limit and programming a threshold

Definition and results

A limit is approached here intuitively. The terms $\dfrac{1}{n+1}$ get closer to 0; n^2 grows without bound; $(-1)^n$ does not settle. A numerical experiment suggests a conclusion but does not prove a behaviour for all indices. A threshold algorithm must specify the direction of the inequality and provide a stopping condition.

Status and justification. Illustrative observations, without a formal theory of limits. The correctness of an integer threshold is checked by examining the index found and the previous index, once monotonicity is established.

Worked example. For $u_n = 80(\dfrac{1}{2})^n$, the first index with $u_n < 6$ is 4: $u_3 = 10 \geq 6$ and $u_4 = 5 < 6$. The program starts with $n = 0, u = 80$ and repeats the division by 2 while $u \geq 6$.

Watch out

A loop with no bound may never stop if the threshold cannot be reached; $<$ and $\leq$ are not interchangeable.

Immediate application. For $u_n = 48(\frac{1}{2})^n$, determine the first indices where $u_n \leq 6$ and where $u_n < 6$.

Exercise path

Start with exercises 1 and 2. Then choose one of exercises 3 or 4 and do it without help. Exercises 5 to 7 are a reserve for transfer, investigation or programming: the teacher designates one. Exercise 8 is revisited after a delay.

Exercise 1.1 – Getting to grips with indices

Consider the sequence (u_n) defined for every natural number n by $u_n = 2n^2 - 3n$. The first term is therefore the one of index 0.

1. Calculate u_0, u_1 and u_4 separately, showing the substitution of n.
2. Express u_{n+1} in terms of n, then expand and simplify this expression.
3. Calculate $u_{n+1} - u_n$. By studying its sign for integer indices, describe the variations of the sequence.

Exercise 1.2 – Choosing the right model

A nursery currently has 100 young plants. It is considering two models to forecast its stock: in model A, the stock increases by 15 plants per month; in model B, it increases by 10 percent per month. Let a_n and b_n be the forecast stocks after n months, with $a_0 = b_0 = 100$. The two models are studied separately.

1. **Model A.** Write the relation between a_{n+1} and a_n. Recognise the type of sequence, then express a_n in terms of n. Calculate a_2.
2. **Model B, after studying geometric sequences.** Answer the same questions for (b_n) and calculate b_2.
3. For each model, explain what is assumed to be constant. Give one reason why a very long-term forecast might become unrealistic.

Exercise 1.3 – Recovering a sequence

The sequence (u_n) is geometric, defined from index 0. Its common ratio q is strictly positive. We only know $u_1 = 6$ and $u_3 = 54$.

1. Determine q by relating the two known terms. Present all the steps that lead to choosing its value.
2. Deduce u_0, then u_5.
3. What would change if the hypothesis $q > 0$ were removed? Give all the possible reasons and explain whether the value of u_5 would be affected.

Exercise 1.4 – Rows of seats

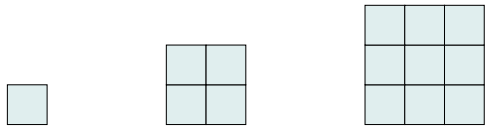
A theatre has 12 rows. The first row has 18 seats; each following row has two more seats than the previous one. Let u_n be the number of seats in row n, for $1 \leq n \leq 12$.

1. Define the sequence (u_n) and calculate the number of seats in the last row.
2. Calculate the total capacity of the theatre. Explain the number of terms used in the sum.
3. Calculate the average number of seats per row and use this result to check the total found.

Exercise 1.5 – Accumulating squares

Patterns are built with identical square tiles. The pattern of index 1 contains one tile. To go from the pattern of index n to that of index $n+1$, we add $2n+1$ tiles. Let u_n be the number of tiles in the pattern of index n, for $n \geq 1$.

1. Calculate u_2 and u_3. Draw an arrangement of these tiles that suggests a formula for u_n.
2. Conjecture an expression for u_n in terms of n.
3. Check that this expression gives the first term and satisfies the construction rule. Explain why these two checks identify the sequence.



Index 1 Index 2 Index 3

One possible arrangement of the first three patterns; the drawing helps to state a conjecture, which still has to be justified.

Exercise 1.6 – Two repayments

A person must repay 600 monetary units, with no interest. Two plans are considered. With plan A, they pay 50 units at the end of each month until the debt is repaid. With plan B, they pay each month half of what they still owe. The calculations for model B are carried out without rounding. Let a_n and b_n be the remaining debts after the payment of month n, with $a_0 = b_0 = 600$.

1. Express a_n until the debt is cleared. In which month is the repayment completed?
2. Express b_n. Determine the first month in which the remaining debt is strictly less than 10 units; check the previous month.
3. In model B without rounding, does the debt become exactly zero after a finite number of months? Justify and comment on the difference with a real situation.

Exercise 1.7 – Reading a list

A program must keep the terms of the sequence defined by $u_0 = 2$ and $u_{n+1} = 3u_n - 1$. It starts with the instructions `u=2` and `L=[u]`. It then executes five times, in this order, `u=3*u-1` then `L.append(u)`.

1. Execute the first two passes of the loop by hand. Then give the contents of the list.

2. How many elements does the list contain at the end of the five passes? What is the index of the last term stored?

3. Write the complete program in Python, then check the value of the last element. Explain why the number of terms exceeds the number of passes by one.

Exercise 1.8 – Delayed review

This question is done one week after the chapter, without consulting the formulas. A sequence is defined for $n \geq 2$ by $u_2 = 12$ and $u_{n+1} = u_n - 3$.

1. Calculate u_7, stating how many passes separate the indices 2 and 7.

2. Calculate the sum $u_2 + u_3 + \cdots + u_7$. Explain the difference between the number of terms in this sum and the number of passes calculated in the first question.

Homework. Do only the task designated at the end of the session, in the dated progression: 10–20 min at most. The exercises depend on the topics already studied, so some questions are deferred. Revisit exercise 8 one week after the chapter (10 min). If the allotted time is exceeded, note the difficulty and bring your attempts; do not pile up the whole reserve.

To do in the CQFD textbook

These exercises are done in your textbook. The progression indicates the session; they replace the homework planned for that day (10 to 20 minutes in total).

CQFD, exercise 9 p. 64, questions a and b. Calculate the first four terms. Write the substitutions before simplifying.

CQFD, exercise 11 p. 64, all questions. Calculate the terms one after another and keep a record of the four steps.

MCQ 1: understand and choose

Five single-answer questions for practice. Choose one answer per question; then explain one distractor. This chapter format does not reproduce the official EAM format.

1. $u_n = 3n + 2$: u_4 equals
   A. 14
   B. 18
   C. 12
   D. 6
2. $u_0 = 2$, $u_{n+1} = u_n + 5$: u_3 equals
   A. 10
   B. 12
   C. 17
   D. 15
3. An increase of 8 % gives the ratio
   A. 0.08
   B. 1.8
   C. 0.92
   D. 1.08
4. From u_3 to u_9 inclusive, there are
   A. 6
   B. 7
   C. 9
   D. 12
5. $1 + 2 + \cdots + 20$ equals
   A. 200
   B. 420
   C. 210
   D. 190

MCQ 2: understand and choose

Five single-answer questions for practice. Choose one answer per question; then explain one distractor. This chapter format does not reproduce the official EAM format.

1. $u_n = -3 \times 2^n$ is
   A. strictly increasing
   B. constant
   C. neither increasing nor decreasing
   D. strictly decreasing
2. $1 + 2 + 4 + 8$ equals
   A. 15
   B. 16
   C. 14

D. 8

3. For $u_n = \dfrac{16}{2^n}$, the first index where $u_n < 2$:

   A. 2

   B. 3

   C. 4

   D. 5

4. The sequence $(-1)^n$

   A. tends to 0

   B. has no limit

   C. is increasing

   D. is constant

5. A list contains u_0 to u_{10}; its length is

   A. 10

   B. 9

   C. 12

   D. 11

True or false? Justify.

1. Every geometric sequence with common ratio $q > 1$ is increasing.
2. If two sequences have their first three terms equal, they are equal.
3. For $q = 1$, $1 + q + \cdots + q^n = n + 1$.

Self-assessment

I distinguish explicit from recurrence definitions; I recognise a constant increment or rate; I count the terms; I check the previous index of a threshold.
For each objective, indicate: achieved without help; achieved with help; to be reworked. Write one example and one mistake to avoid.